opportunities to play representative rugby and I was fortunate to be selected for the Blue Bulls Under-18 team, and later the Under-19 team, wearing the famous light-blue jersey, playing at Loftus Versfeld, and still always dreaming of playing at a higher level.

I was also selected to play in the Blue Bulls high-school team competing in the 2002 Craven Week at Woodburn Stadium in Pietermaritzburg. We had a strong squad, including Pierre Spies and Derick Kuün from Affies, as well as Chiliboy Ralepelle from Boys' High, but my oldest friend at the tournament was captain of the KwaZulu-Natal team, playing at home and our opponents in the last match of the opening day.

Antonie Claassen is the son of Wynand Claassen, Springbok captain on the famous 'demo' tour to New Zealand in 1981 and one of my father's oldest and closest friends from their days at Tukkies. Our families have been friends for as long as I can remember, and a photograph of me and Antonie when we were four years old shows us wearing our respective Bulls and Natal rugby jerseys. Fourteen years on, an identical photograph was taken of the two of us wearing larger Bulls and Natal jerseys before the match at the Craven Week.

Antonie would eventually move to France, settle there, and enjoy a fine professional career, playing club rugby for Brive, Castres and Racing Metro, and win six caps for the French national team.

The Bulls-Natal match at Woodburn Stadium attracted plenty of media attention, with reports covering a full page in the *Beeld* newspaper, and we started strongly, taking an early lead. However, Peter Grant was playing flyhalf for KwaZulu-Natal and, showing the talent he would subsequently take to Western Province and the Stormers, he seized control all on his own, scoring two tries and guiding the home side to a 36–32 comeback win.

That dramatic defeat at the 2002 Craven Week would be the pinnacle of my career in rugby.

By then, it had become clear that my future lay on the cricket field.